



SELECTBOARD

TOWN OF WESTHAMPTON
TOWN HALL
1 SOUTH ROAD
WESTHAMPTON, MASSACHUSETTS 01027

Selectboard Minutes of November 22, 2021

The Westhampton Selectboard scheduled a regular meeting on Monday, November 22, 2021, at 7 PM.

Pursuant to Chapter 20 of the Acts of 2021, attendance was by remote access only. Members of the public attended the meeting via "Zoom" conferencing. Meeting ID Code: 8704 390 0582. There was no in-person attendance by the public. The meeting was audio/video recorded for purposes of minutes only.

Call to Order – Call of Role

The meeting was called to order at 7:01 PM.

Present: Phil Dowling, Teri Anderson, Maureen Dempsey. Quorum declared.

Also present: Marilyn R Witherell, Bill Jablonski (Highway Dept), Barbara Pelissier, Susan Bronstein, Roberta Armenti, Douglas Finn.

Scheduled Business

Department and Committee Updates

Highway Department

Mr. Jablonski noted that the highway department had been busy with sealing cracks, leaf-cleanup; training for staff on snow and ice management. A recent rainstorm resulted in significant washouts, and the crew worked on Saturday. Flags were installed and removed for Veterans Day.

Mr. Jablonski also noted that he was pursuing completion of the mezzanine at the highway department; this would enable the storage of fire-department equipment off of the main floor, and allow snowplows to be placed indoors for repair, service, and checks prior to snow season.

Mr. Jablonski further noted that the Kings Highway bridge project was moving forward, with some work remaining to be done before the road is opened.

SMRP "Recycling Dividend Program" Grant: Contract Review; signatory authorization

Mr. Jablonski noted approval of the DEP solid waste grant, and requested a vote to accept, and vote to authorize signatory for the contract.

It was MOVED by Dowling, SECONDED by Dempsey,

To accept the grant, and authorize Mr. Dowling to sign on behalf of the board.

VOTED: Dempsey: Yes; Anderson: Yes; Dowling: Yes. (7:03 PM)

Ms. Dempsey thanked Mr. Jablonski for the recent removal of bittersweet from the front of Town Hall.

Town Property & Energy Assessment Committee

No report. The committee will report at the next regular meeting.

Administrative Assistant

Mr. Finn presented three draft policies:

- Public Meeting Posting Policy
- Key Policy
- Credit Card Policy

Mr. Finn noted that the three policies were based on other town's similar policies, and that no action was requested at this time. Mr. Dowling noted that the board would review, and the matter would be taken up at a later meeting.

Mr. Finn noted that there were errors in posting the agenda to the town website; while not a legal impact, he acknowledged the inconvenience, and would work to improve the process moving forward.

Mr. Finn noted that he would be coordinating his schedule with the financial team at the Annex, in order to improve communication. Office Hours would be Monday through Thursday (during weeks with Selectboard meetings) and Tuesday through Friday (on opposite weeks).

Other Boards / Committees / Project updates

Municipal Vulnerability Plan – Teri Anderson

Ms. Anderson noted that the committee had its kickoff meeting, and requested formal appointment of committee members. A list of members were reviewed.

It was MOVED by Dowling, SECONDED by Anderson

To appoint the following to the MVP Action Grant Core Group:

<i>Phil Dowling</i>	<i>Teri Anderson</i>	<i>Laurie Sanders</i>
<i>Robby Armenti</i>	<i>Fred Morrison</i>	<i>Susan Bronstein</i>
<i>Morley Cleary</i>	<i>Julia Lennon</i>	<i>Pat Miller</i>
<i>Bill Tracy</i>	<i>Arthur Clapp</i>	<i>John Zimmerman</i>

VOTED: Dempsey: Yes; Anderson: Yes; Dowling: Yes. (7:12 PM)

It was MOVED by Dowling, SECONDED by Anderson

To appoint to the MVP Open Space and Recreation Subgroup:

<i>Laurie Sanders</i>	<i>Fred Morrison</i>	<i>Bob LaPalme</i>
<i>Jennifer Milikowsky</i>	<i>Pandora Redwin</i>	<i>Carter Cleary</i>
<i>Dante Volkman Ternullo</i>	<i>Kate Parsons</i>	<i>Tom Jenkins</i>

VOTED: Dempsey: Yes; Anderson: Yes; Dowling: Yes. (7:13 PM)

Ms. Anderson noted that there would be multiple opportunities for public input at several upcoming events, and the public would be notified and invited to participate.

Planning Board Appointments: John Zimmerman, others

In order to fill out empty positions, it was MOVED by Dowling, SECONDED by Anderson

To appoint Maureen Dempsey and John Zimmerman as members of the Planning Board, to fill a position through the next annual election.

VOTED: Dempsey: Yes; Anderson: Yes; Dowling: Yes. (7:15 PM)

Mr. Finn noted that he would notify Mr. Zimmerman of his appointment.

Public Safety Building Update – Phil Dowling

FRTA Update

Ms. Anderson noted that the Annual assessment to the Town would be \$130 per year. This accounts for .03% of the funding, and a weighted vote of 1.02%. She also noted that the FRTA board voted to waive rider fares through June 30, 2022, and likely will be extended beyond that date, if funding is available. Finally: FRTA is looking for drivers, and is willing to train and license new drivers.

CARES Update – Susan Bronstein

Ms. Bronstein noted that distributions continue, and she is waiting for notice of the next reporting deadline. She noted that CARES act funding ends as of the end of the year.

Mr. Dowling noted that the Town Hall 'video conferencing' project was ongoing, with limited success, but that he and Mr. Finn would continue to pursue equipment.

There was some discussion about the previously proposed shed for the library; Mr. Dowling noted that the library trustees had decided not to pursue the structure. There was some discussion about storage options for the library.

Public Safety Building Update – Phil Dowling

Mr. Dowling noted that concrete floor pouring was due to happen this week. The location of the generator is required to be moved. Building components are still being constructed, with a due date uncertain at this time.

Additional Funding for Public Safety Complex

Mr. Dowling noted that he was working on additional potential ARPA funding for the Public Safety Complex project; the potential is still up in the air; however, letters of support to key state representatives would be drafted and sent in the next week.

The board discussed the past use of existing ARPA funds, the potential use of ARPA funding for EMT training, and other details.

Selectboard Business

Ms. Anderson: 3G Service Discontinuance / Equipment for Highway / Police / Fire (CARES funding?)

Ms. Anderson noted the discontinuance of 3G service, anticipated to begin at the end of February. The impact of the end of service was discussed, from the perspective of town departments to that of private residents. Various online resources were discussed, and the

board considered ways to get the information out to town residents.

Review Correspondence

Mr. Finn noted correspondence from Comcast detailed price increases for virtually every itemized service, including cable box rental, basic service, sports channels, premium channels, and etc. Price increases were due to 'investments' in their network, rising programming costs for local sports and programming, and other factors. Price increases are due to take effect on December 20.

Mr. Finn noted that the franchise agreement is up in about two years. Mr. Finn also requested permission to contact Comcast and renegotiate costs for internet and VOIP services. Approved by acclamation.

Finally, Mr. Finn noted that, moving forward, Selectboard meeting materials would be available in advance of the meeting through a link on the website. There was some discussion as to whether or not warrants could or should be made publicly available.

Review minutes of November 8, 2021

The Board reviewed the draft minutes of November 8. Ms. Anderson noted the omission of "Resilient Master Plan" from the list of MVP project goals. Mr. Finn confirmed a correction would be made.

It was MOVED by Dowling, SECONDED by Dempsey

To approve the Minutes of November 8, as amended.

VOTE: Dowling: Yes; Anderson: Yes; Dempsey: Yes. (7:47 PM)

Review and approval of warrants

Mr. Dowling noted that the warrants were available for review, and asked for comments or corrections.

It was MOVED by Anderson, SECONDED by Dempsey

To approve the warrants as presented.

VOTE: Dowling: Yes; Anderson: Yes; Dempsey: Yes. (7:49 PM)

Any other issues to come before the board not reasonably anticipated at time of posting

Mr. Finn requested permission to pursue better rates for internet and telephone service from Comcast. Approved.

There was some discussion related to outstanding invoices from Hackworth. Mr. Finn noted that the matter was still being pursued.

Ms. Dempsey asked if Mr. Finn could continue to pursue options for an animal control officer for Westhampton. Agreed.

Ms. Pelissier noted that there seemed to still be issues related to delivery of public notices through the website. Mr. Finn agreed to pursue the issue and to try to resolve any problems.

Ms. Witherell noted that she no longer receives notices on her 'Comcast' email, but is getting them on her 'Gmail' account. Ms. Anderson suggested that the problem would likely be with Comcast, and suggested sticking with her Gmail account for the time being.

Ms. Anderson asked Mr. Finn to send a response to the proponent of the name change for the October Holiday. Agreed.

Schedule Next Meeting and Adjourn

Mr. Dowling noted that the next meeting would be held at 7:00 p.m. on December 6, 2021.

It was MOVED by Dowling, SECONDED by Dempsey

To adjourn.

VOTE: Dowling: Yes; Anderson: Yes; Dempsey: Yes. (8:03 PM)

Respectfully submitted,

Douglas Finn

Minutes approved by a vote of the Selectboard at a regular meeting held on December 6, 2021.



Phil Dowling



Maureen Dempsey

Teri Anderson